



Ten Lesser Known Commands for Linux Users

The ten Linux commands listed in this article are not well known but can be pretty useful for systems administrators.

Linux is so vast that even after working with it for a few years, we keep discovering new commands that enable us to do our tasks more efficiently and productively. I have compiled a few commands and utilities that will be useful to administrators and even typical users.

1. The *watch* command

The *watch* command can be used to repeat a command at fixed intervals. The default interval is 2 seconds or the users can set their own interval with the *-n* option. To run the free command every 5 seconds, use the following command:

```
Swatch -d -n 5 free
```

The *-d* option highlights the change, which is a really useful option. Type *Ctrl-C* to quit and come back to the prompt.

2. An audible ping

The *ping* command is often used to check whether a server or a link is up. We may have to wait for some time, and if you don't want to watch the screen continuously when you are busy doing something else, the solution is to make the ping audible by using the *-a* option.

```
Ping -a 192.168.10.1
```

3. Overwriting a file

The operating system does not completely erase a file when the file is deleted. The file could be recovered by third party forensic tools. But we can use the *shred* command to overwrite a file, to make it almost impossible for it to be recovered. The file is overwritten three times, by default, which can be changed by the *-n* option.

```
$shred -n 5 trial.txt
```

The above command will overwrite the file *trial.txt* five times. The *-u* option can be used to remove a file after overwriting.

```
$shred -u trial.txt
```

The *shred* tool may not work in journaling file systems and RAID file systems.

Even the 'srm' (secure remove) and 'wipe' utilities can be used to securely remove a file, though they are not installed by default in most Linux systems.

4. The *file* command

The *file* command is used to know what type the file is. The command is shown below:

```
$file filename
```